



REPUBLIC OF UGANDA

Ministry of ICT and National Guidance

EXPLAINER NOTE

Source Code: Why We Ask for It and How It Is Protected

Government Systems Prototype Showcase — Explainer Note for Applicants

This note is addressed to all innovators who have submitted or intend to submit a prototype under the Government Systems Prototype Showcase. It explains why the Ministry of ICT and National Guidance (MoICT&NG) requests access to source code, what that access involves, and what protections are in place for your intellectual property.

1. WHAT IS BEING REQUESTED

The Application Form invites — but does not require — applicants to provide a read-only link to their source code repository. This is listed as a Recommended submission item. It is not mandatory, and an application shall not be disqualified for omitting it.

The request is for read-only access only. This means the Ministry and the Evaluation Panel shall be able to view the code but shall not be able to copy, download, modify, or execute it through the repository link. Applicants shall grant access on a time-limited basis, using standard repository access controls available on platforms such as GitHub, GitLab, or Bitbucket.

2. WHY THE MINISTRY REQUESTS SOURCE CODE ACCESS

Government systems must meet a higher standard of trust than most commercial applications. When the Ministry considers a system for public deployment, it must be confident that the system is genuinely built — not a demonstration shell — and that it is built in a way that can be maintained, secured, and extended over the long term. Source code review is one of the most reliable ways to make that assessment.

1. Confirming the system is real. A working prototype can be demonstrated without underlying code, but a demonstration alone cannot confirm that the system is production-ready or that the core functionality is fully implemented. Code review allows the technical panel to verify that what is shown is genuinely built.
2. Assessing code quality and engineering standards. The evaluation framework awards points for code quality, version control discipline, testing practices, and documentation. These can only be assessed through direct inspection of the codebase.
3. Identifying security risks early. Government systems handle sensitive citizen data. The panel shall look for common security vulnerabilities, hardcoded credentials, insecure data handling practices, and the absence of input validation — issues that may not be visible in a live demonstration but that would create serious risks if the system were deployed at scale.
4. Understanding maintainability. A system that cannot be understood, extended, or handed over to a Government technical team is not deployable regardless of how well it functions today.

Code review allows the panel to assess whether the system is built in a maintainable and documented way.

5. Verifying the technology stack. The application asks applicants to declare their technology stack. Source code review confirms that the declared stack matches the actual implementation, and allows the panel to assess whether the chosen technologies are appropriate for a Government context.

3. HOW YOUR INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY IS PROTECTED

The Ministry is aware that source code is often the most sensitive and commercially valuable asset an innovator holds. The following protections shall be in place throughout the evaluation process.

3.1 Intellectual Property Remains Yours

Providing access to your source code does not transfer any intellectual property rights to the Ministry or the Government of Uganda. Ownership of the code remains entirely with you. The Ministry shall not claim any rights over your code, your system design, or any proprietary algorithms as a result of the evaluation process. This is stated explicitly in the Call to Ugandan Innovators.

3.2 Access is Read-Only and Time-Limited

Access shall be granted at the read-only level and shall be limited to the period of technical evaluation. Once evaluation is complete, you shall be notified and requested to revoke access. The Ministry shall confirm in writing when access has been closed. You retain full control of your repository at all times and may revoke access at any point.

3.3 Access is Restricted to the Technical Evaluation Panel

Repository access shall only be shared with members of the Technical Evaluation Panel who have been formally constituted by the Permanent Secretary for this purpose. Panel members shall sign a confidentiality undertaking before participating in the evaluation. The undertaking shall prohibit them from sharing, reproducing, or using any code or design information for any purpose outside the evaluation.

3.4 Code is Not Stored or Reproduced

The Ministry shall not download, copy, or store your source code during the evaluation. Panel members shall conduct their review through the access link provided and shall record only their evaluation scores and qualitative observations in the GDR system. No code shall be reproduced in evaluation reports or any other Ministry document.

3.5 Confidentiality Applies to All Submissions

The evaluation process is confidential. Panel members shall not disclose the existence, content, or quality of any submission to any person outside the panel. The GDR system records access logs for all evaluation activity, providing an auditable trail of who accessed what and when.

4. WHAT HAPPENS IF YOU CHOOSE NOT TO SHARE SOURCE CODE

Providing source code access is recommended, not required. Applicants who choose not to share source code shall still be evaluated across all eight domains of the evaluation framework. However, the panel's ability to fully assess Technical Soundness and Architecture (Section B, worth 25 points) and Security, Privacy and Compliance (Section D, worth 15 points) shall be limited to what can be assessed through documentation, the architecture diagram, and the live demonstration. Applicants

are encouraged to compensate for this by providing a detailed written description of their technical architecture and security measures.

5. HOW TO SHARE YOUR SOURCE CODE

The following steps shall be used to share read-only access securely:

1. **GitHub:** Go to Settings > Collaborators, add the Ministry's designated reviewer account as a collaborator with 'Read' access. The reviewer account details shall be provided to shortlisted applicants via the GDR portal.
2. **GitLab:** Go to Project Settings > Members, add the reviewer as a Guest (read-only role).
3. **Bitbucket:** Go to Repository Settings > User and group access, add the reviewer with 'Read' permission.
4. **Private repository on other platforms:** Contact support@gdr.go.ug for guidance on how to provide secure access.

Do not share your repository password or personal access tokens. Use only the repository's built-in access management tools to grant read-only access to a specific account.

6. SUMMARY

Question	Answer
Is source code mandatory?	No. It is recommended. Omitting it shall not disqualify your application.
What level of access is granted?	Read-only. The panel can view code but cannot copy, modify, or execute it.
Who sees the code?	Only constituted panel members who have signed a confidentiality undertaking.
Does sharing code transfer IP?	No. Intellectual property remains with the innovator at all times.
Can I revoke access?	Yes. You may revoke access at any time. The Ministry shall confirm closure.
Is the code stored by Government?	No. No code is downloaded, copied, or reproduced by the Ministry.
What if I don't share code?	You shall still be evaluated, but Sections B and D scores may be limited.

Government Systems Prototype Showcase | Ministry of ICT and National Guidance |
gdr.go.ug/innovators-showcase